When multi-hyphenates Ankur Tewari and Swanand Kirkire decided to collaborate, the idea was to attempt something neither had done before. "We wanted to write a long-format story. Considering we are both musicians, music had to be integral to what we were creating," says Kirkire. The result is Amazon Prime Video's *Bandwaale*, a musical series set in Ratlam, Madhya Pradesh, that follows a young poetess on a journey of self-discovery and freedom. Directed by Akshat Verma, the series stars Shalini Pandey, Zahan Kapoor and Ashish Vidyarthi. As brass band singer Robo Kumar, Kirkire is on double duty.

Kirkire had first worked with Tewari in 2016 when the latter was directing a series of short films for YashRaj Films. This, in turn, led to the duo exchanging ideas and stories. "We are both from small towns—he's from Roorkee and I am from Indore. Given our upbringing and influences, though Ankur and I are very different as people. This show is a reflection of both of us." Work on *Bandwaale* started pre-pandemic but eventually picked up steam towards the end, with writing sessions over Zoom.

The two-time winner of the National Film Award for Best Lyrics describes the process of writing a longform story as both "humbling and exhilarating". "As a poet, I am used to writing a few lines but writing this show was like writing a novel, where you have to keep track of multiple characters and their arcs." The biggest challenge? "Keeping the screenplay alive, which means that the pacing has to be correct and every scene drives the narrative forward."

Switching between being the show's creator and one of its lead actors was a constant struggle. "I had given myself very strict instructions that when I am on set, I am only an actor, and Akshat's would be the final word." While this works in theory, Kirkire quickly discovered it was difficult once he was actually on set. "My focus was always divided between my job as an actor and keeping track of what other actors were doing with the characters we had created."

To write Robo, the 55-year-old drew from people he had come across while growing up in Indore. "These are people who are so influenced by cinema that their grip on reality has loosened. There was one man who thought Sanjay Dutt was his elder brother." Robo is possibly one of the most delusional (yet likeable) characters Kirkire has ever played. "This was a difficult character to both write and perform because he could very easily become a caricature. We had to walk a fine line."

Bandwaale, though, Kirkire quickly reminds us, is the story of Mariam and not Robo. "He is one of the people she approaches for help, but like everyone she approaches, he also ends up creating more trouble for her." This is a recurring theme in the show. While Robo is helping Mariam, she doesn't realise that he's in love with her and that his band members have taken to calling her 'bhabhi'. "There's one man who is her 'rakhi brother', another an uncle, but none of them can look beyond Mariam's gender to see a fellow human being. Everyone has an agenda."

The show is about a young poetess on a journey of self-discovery, subjected to romantic attention from peers who refuse to see her as anything but a woman



Swanand Kirkire, Shalini Pandey and Zahan Kapoor in *Bandwaale*